U.S. Industrial Production — 107-Year Historical Context

Generated: 2026-06-16 15:38 | Series: INDPRO (Federal Reserve) | Period: 1919-01-01 to 2026-05-01 | 1,289 monthly observations | Source: FRED via Thor Storehouse

The Federal Reserve's Industrial Production Index (INDPRO) measures real output of U.S. manufacturing, mining, and utilities. Indexed to 2017 = 100, it is one of the most reliable long-run indicators of U.S. economic health — and one of the few series with continuous monthly data back to 1919. This report puts the current reading in the context of every major crisis of the past 107 years. All data sourced from FRED. No opinion. No forecasting. #FollowTheData

CURRENT READING

102.6

Index (2017 = 100)

May 2026 · +2.6% above 2017 baseline

107-YEAR GROWTH

+2006%

since Jan 1919

4.8739 → 102.6475

GREAT DEPRESSION DROP

53.1%

Aug 1929 → Jul 1932

Equivalent today: index falls to 48

12-MONTH TREND

▲ 1.7%

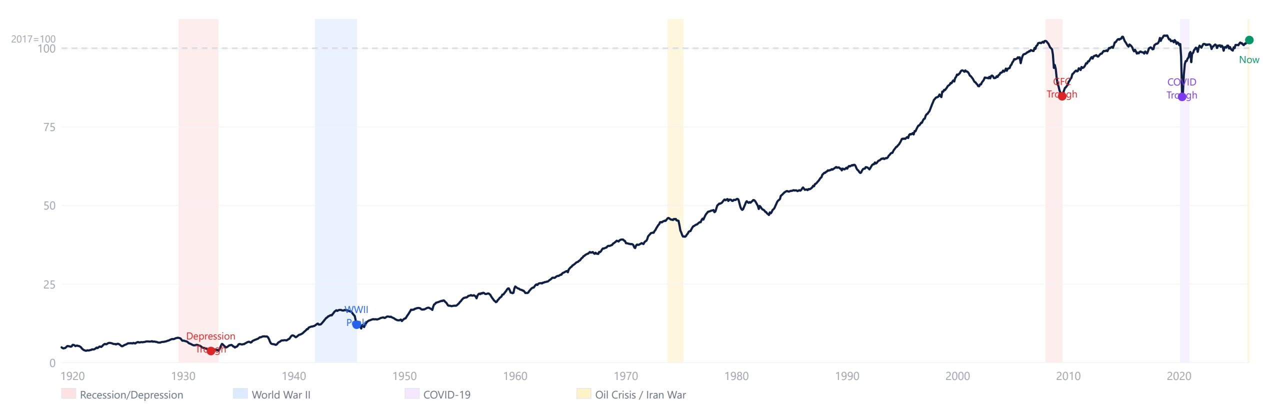
May 2025 → May 2026

vs pre-COVID peak: +1.3%

INDPRO — FULL HISTORY 1919–2026

FRED · 1,289 MONTHLY OBSERVATIONS · DETERMINISTIC

Index: 2017 = 100 · Shaded regions = major crises · Dashed line = 2017 baseline



MAJOR CRISIS COMPARISON

Crisis	Peak	Trough	Duration	Drop	Recovery
Great Depression	Aug 1929	Jul 1932	~3.5 years	53.1%	Industrial production did not regain its 1929 peak until wartime mobilization for World War II
Global Financial Crisis	Dec 2007	Jun 2009	18 months	-17.2%	4 years to recover pre-GFC levels
COVID-19	Feb 2020	Apr 2020	2 months	-16.6%	12 months to full recovery — fastest in history

COVID-19 had the fastest collapse (2 months) and fastest recovery (12 months) in 107 years of data. The Great Depression drop of 53.1% would require the current index to fall from 102.6 to 48 — a level last seen in the 1930s.

WHERE ARE WE NOW?

U.S. industrial production in May 2026 stands at 102.6 on the 2017=100 index — +1.3% above the pre-COVID peak of 101.4 (February 2020) and +0.3% above the pre-GFC peak of 102.4 (December 2007).

Industrial production did not regain its 1929 pre-Depression peak until the wartime mobilization of World War II — a gap of more than 15 years. By contrast, the GFC recovery took 4 years, and COVID recovered in approximately 12 months.

To put the Great Depression in modern context: a 53.1% decline from today's level would drive INDPRO to 48 — a level not seen since the late 1930s, before wartime mobilization restored industrial output.

THE COVID RECORD

COVID-19 produced both the **fastest collapse** and the **fastest recovery** in 107 years of U.S. industrial production history.

Collapse	**-16.6%**
Time to trough	**2 months**
Time to full recovery	**~12 months**
vs. GFC recovery	**4x faster**
vs. Depression recovery	**15+ years faster**

The same event that produced the fastest collapse in modern history also produced the fastest recovery. No prior crisis came close on either metric.

Data Source: Industrial Production Index (INDPRO) published by the Board of Governors of the Federal Reserve System, sourced via FRED API and stored in Thor Storehouse database. Index base year: 2017 = 100. Monthly frequency. 1,289 observations covering January 1919 through May 2026.

Methodology: All figures computed deterministically from timestamped FRED data. No forecasting. No opinion. Same input always produces identical output. Crisis periods defined by NBER recession dates and historical reference. #FollowTheData · AI narrates. Data decides.